

ANSWER KEY: END-SEMESTER EXAM

Section B: Literature

Overall points for the Literature module:

An answer that gets the basic minimum should get about 5 or 6.

An answer that gets the basic minimum, writes it thoughtfully and thoroughly, should get about 7 or 7.5.

An answer that not only the basic minimum, but additional points mentioned below, should get 8 or 8.5, with 8.5 being an outstanding response.

1. What was Alice Walker seeking that she found in Zora Neale Hurston?

- This is a summary of the basic minimum this answer requires: Alice Walker's search as an African-American woman writer searching for information and insights about Black folklore, esp. voodoo, in the context of her own work; struggle to find anything; all knowledge and frameworks for thinking about Black culture came from white writers and scholars. Her entire essay is preoccupied with the question of models for not only artists in general, but of the importance of models for African-American writers to look up, learn from, emulate etc; this aspect should be described. It is in this context that she discovers the forgotten/neglected/marginalized work of Zora Neale Hurston, a writer and anthropologist, who had rigorously documented and studied Black folklore and other forms of culture. Her thoughts on this experience of (re)discovery should be explored in the response.
- More points for students who do one or more of the following:
 - connect the question of literature and culture to the social and historical context of race and racism and, therefore, the importance of representation of under-represented marginalized or oppressed communities in culture and the study of culture;
 - who mention/discuss the other African-American writers and scholars that Walker mentions/discusses in the context of culture and representation;
 - connect the search for models to the search for a tradition in which an artist can envisage themselves or carve out a career.

2. Why does Terry Eagleton write that reading literature is different from reading "an account of the incidence of soil erosion"? Explain the difference and cite one example from the Eagleton reading or from class discussions. [5+5]

- This is a summary of the basic minimum this answer requires: the difference lies in "literariness" – with literature, how something is said is as or even more important than what is said – rhetoric – the importance of language, imagery,

tone, reading between the lines – any example that Eagleton discusses in detail, e.g. Forster's *A Passage to India*, Jane Austen's *Pride and Prejudice* etc.

- More points for students who some or more of the following:
 - Go beyond basic interpretation or context and offer deep/rigorous readings and discussions of either examples from Eagleton or the poetry discussed in class, which demonstrate what “literariness” or literary qualities are.
 - Students who connect Amrita Pritam's poem and the metonym of Punjabiya to this question of “literariness.”

3. a. List three ways of defining Comparative Literature.

- This is a summary of the basic minimum this answer requires: any three of the different ways of defining CompLit that are covered in slides 11-16 of Lecture 4 are acceptable.
- More points for students who mention, in addition to the points above, one or more of the following:
 - Matthew Arnold's point about connection, Tagore's concept of vishwasahitya, Goethe's weltliteratur.
 - Amrita Pritam's invocation of Waris Shah as an example of how the study of Indian literatures is/should be fundamentally comparative.
 - Aijaz Ahmad's insights about “Indian literature” as a category, as discussed in class and in slides 18-19.

b. What is the difference between art, crafts, and pop art?

- This is a summary of the basic minimum this answer requires: hierarchy of useful and beautiful knowledge, hierarchy within the idea of art/creativity; the difference between the concept (high/low/elite/mass) and the creators (artists, artisans, performers; lone artist vs. community of artisans).
- More points for students who cover one or more of the following:
 - the role of the market in determining the value of art and what we value in art (artistic qualities, rarity, historical age etc).
 - irony and popular art, its references to mass culture.

Section C:

5. Write an essay about the concepts of classic and canon and explain how these developed in the Indian context.

An answer that gets the basic minimum should get about 10-11.

An answer that gets the basic minimum, writes it thoughtfully and thoroughly, should get about 12-13.

An answer that not only the basic minimum, but additional points mentioned below, should get between 14-16, with 16 being an outstanding response.

- Basic minimum: Assumption of intrinsic value (spiritual, moral, artistic/creative) of certain texts, no need for questioning, external factors assumed to not exist, but both classic and canon are historically constituted; Macaulay's Minute and the colonial project and the establishment of English literature departments and canons; the independence struggle and the creation of a canon of Indian literature.
- More points for students who cover one or more of the following:
 - First, this should be an essay, so give more points to students who write in full sentences and paragraphs. Cryptic phrases in bullet points will not do, narrative responses are required.
 - Detailed deliberation about the historical constitution of "classics," including examples covered in class, such as ancient Greek theatre, Shakespeare's plays, Kalidasa's *Meghaduta*.
 - The primacy of print and middle-class values and how that marginalizes other forms of verbal creativity and modes of knowledge that do not fall in that category.